



SUNDAY SCHOOL SIMPLIFIED

**THE GOSPEL
ACCORDING
— TO THE —
WOMEN**

Vol. 02

A SIX LESSON PACKET

A LETTER FROM THE CANDLER FOUNDRY

Dear Friend,

Some of the most important people in the Bible are also the easiest to read past — the women whose faith, courage, and cunning quietly move the whole story of God's people forward.

"Hannah, who prayed out of her grief."

"Shiphrah and Puah, who defied a king."

"Tamar, who refused to be erased."

The Gospel According to the Women is an invitation to slow down with six of these women — Hannah, the two daughters of Mark 5, Shiphrah and Puah, the daughters of Zelophehad, Tamar, and the widow of Zarephath — and to read their stories in their own right, with the help of biblical scholarship.

We've designed these lessons to be easy — you can study on your own or with a group, no leader necessary.

We're glad you're here. May the faith and courage of these women meet you in a new way.

Grace and peace,

THE CANDLER FOUNDRY

IN THIS PACKET

- | | | |
|---|-------------------------|---------------|
| 1 | Hannah | 1 SAMUEL 1 |
| 2 | The Two Daughters | MARK 5 |
| 3 | Shiphrah & Puah | EXODUS 1 |
| 4 | Daughters of Zelophehad | NUMBERS 26-27 |
| 5 | Tamar | GENESIS 38 |
| 6 | The Widow of Zarephath | 1 KINGS 17 |

THE RHYTHM OF EACH LESSON

- | | | | | |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------|--|-----------------------------|--------------------|
| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 |
| Open with prayer. | Read the passage out loud as a group. | Watch the provided 3-Minute Bible video. | Talk through the questions. | Close with prayer. |

LESSON ONE

HANNAH

1 Samuel 1:1–20



OPENING PRAYER

Gracious God, quiet our minds as we read the story of Hannah. Open our ears to hear what the Holy Spirit is saying to us through these ancient words. Show us what this story reveals about you, and the lives you call us to lead. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

1 Samuel 1:1–20

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway — or scan the code](#)



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Grace: The Story of Hannah

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 How does the narrator describe Hannah's relationship with her family, including her husband Elkanah and his other wife Peninnah? To what extent does Hannah's childless state inform those relationships?
 - 2 With no male offspring to support her, Hannah faced a potentially ruinous eventuality of becoming a childless widow — one of the most vulnerable members of society. Further, in the patriarchal setting of this narrative, Hannah's prestige was directly tied to her fertility. How does this context inform Hannah's prayers and concerns?
 - 3 Hannah vows to give the very son she is begging for back to God as a nazirite, dedicated to the Lord (v. 11). As a nazirite, her son would be raised at the sanctuary, not at home with Hannah. Why do you think Hannah would have made this promise, and what do you make of it? Does it inform our understanding of her motivations for wanting a child? (No wrong answers!)
 - 4 As the video explains, Hannah's infertility was understood as a matter of God withholding a pregnancy, such that the cure for infertility was prayer. Indeed, God hears Hannah's prayer and she eventually bears three sons and two daughters (1 Sam 2:21). How have Hannah's social prospects changed as a result of her childbearing? What is the narrator communicating to us about the nature of God, and God's concern for our real-world problems?
 - 5 Hannah prays "out of my great anxiety and vexation" (v. 16) — she's so distressed that the priest Eli mistakenly believes her to be drunk. When you are in real grief, what does your own praying tend to look like?
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CLOSING PRAYER

Loving God, you are the one who meets us exactly where we are - in our longing, grief, and hope. Give us the courage to bring our whole selves before you. Give us compassion for ourselves and for others. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

LESSON TWO

THE TWO DAUGHTERS

Mark 5:21–43



OPENING PRAYER

God of compassion, still our hearts as we hear the stories of these two daughters. Help us sit with the fear, suffering, faith, and hope. Through the Holy Spirit, show us what this passage reveals about your healing love and the life you call us to share. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Mark 5:21–43

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway — or scan the code](#)



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

What is a Markan sandwich?

3-Minute Bible video

[Watch on Vimeo — or scan the code](#)



DID YOU KNOW?

Mark preserves Jesus's actual Aramaic words to the girl - *talitha koum*, 'little girl, get up.' It's one of the few places in the Gospels where we hear Jesus in his own language.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 Mark is famously sparse with words, telling the reader only the necessary information without much descriptive detail. Take a few minutes and imagine the details that Mark omitted. What sights, smells, and sounds do you imagine as you read? What tones of voice were used by each person as they spoke?
- 2 What context does Mark give us about the bleeding woman? Aside from her physical condition, how does Mark indicate the other ways she suffers?
- 3 Being on the social fringes as she was, the bleeding woman would need to have summoned a particular boldness to struggle through the crowd and touch Jesus. What emotions do you imagine she feels as she reaches for Jesus's cloak?
- 4 Jesus gives life to both the woman and the girl, but in very different contexts. What does restoration and healing look like for each of them?
- 5 The bleeding woman's lowly social status contrasts sharply with that of Jairus - a prominent synagogue leader who nonetheless begs at Jesus's feet for his daughter's healing. How does Mark use these narratives to demonstrate Jesus's power to overcome all boundaries - including social obstacles and even death itself?
- 6 How does Mark work to show us a Jesus that is both divine, but also tender and human?



CLOSING PRAYER

God of love, you call each of us as your beloved children. No person is beyond your notice or care. Help us to follow in the way of Jesus, having tender hearts and compassion for our neighbors. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

LESSON THREE

SHIPRAH & PUAH

Exodus 1:8–22



OPENING PRAYER

God of courage, quiet our hearts as we hear the story of Shiprah and Puah. Open our eyes to the choices they made in the face of fear and power. Through the Holy Spirit, help us discern what is right and trust that you have equipped us to act with wisdom and faith. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Exodus 1:8–22

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway — or scan the code](#)



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Background to the Exodus

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Pharaoh in this story, the most powerful man in the world, is never named. The two midwives are: Shiprah and Puah.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 The story never tells us how Shiprah and Puah responded when Pharaoh gave them his command. He apparently expected them to obey, and the narrative doesn't tell us much about how the women responded, deliberated between themselves, or formed a plan. Using your imagination, help fill in these narrative gaps. What might the women have said to Pharaoh? To each other? To the other midwives in their community, and to expectant Hebrew mothers?
- 2 Scholars debate whether Shiprah and Puah were Hebrew midwives or non-Hebrew midwives who served Hebrew women. How does the story change if they were protecting people outside their own community? What risks did they face for their defiance of Pharaoh? What might have led them to take that risk?
- 3 Pharaoh orders the midwives to kill the boys but let the girls live, apparently assuming that girls pose no threat to him. Yet women repeatedly defeat his plan. What does Pharaoh fail to understand about where true power resides?
- 4 Shiprah and Puah receive no instructions from God - no burning bush, no voice from above. The text says only that they "feared God" (v. 17), which in the Old Testament isn't terror but something like conscience: a reverence that refuses to harm the vulnerable. What does this tell us about our human capacity to discern God's will, even when we cannot hear God's voice?
- 5 Looking back, it's easy for us to see Pharaoh's command as evil, and the midwives' acts as faithful disobedience. In our own lives, it's often harder to discern where we are called to disobey on moral or ethical grounds. Have you ever faced a choice between your conscience and following an authority? How did you respond?



CLOSING PRAYER

Faithful God, you give us courage to choose what is right, even when it comes at a cost. Give us wisdom to recognize injustice, strength to resist it, and trust that even small acts of faithfulness can help bring life and hope. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

LESSON FOUR

DAUGHTERS OF ZELOPHEHAD

Numbers 26:52–56; 27:1–11



OPENING PRAYER

Gracious God, gather our attention as we turn to Scripture. We ask that you deepen our understanding of who you are and how you call us to live together. By your Spirit, give us curiosity, wisdom, and openness to hear something new. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Numbers 26:52–56; 27:1–11

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

The Daughters of Zelophehad

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 This lesson's passages reflect the Israelites' plans to allocate the promised land among the various families. Distributing the land fairly was essential, because the Israelites survived primarily on food grown on their respective families' land. Land was passed patrilineally, meaning through male heirs. Keeping this in mind, what are the daughters' circumstances in the wake of their father's death, and how are they now uniquely vulnerable?
 - 2 How does the narrator build dramatic tension as the daughters approach Moses? What makes their legal claim, and the manner in which they present it, particularly bold?
 - 3 How is the issue at hand relevant beyond the daughters themselves? How does the outcome affect their descendants? Other men without sons, and their daughters? The community at large?
 - 4 What is Moses' role in resolving the question the daughters pose? Who actually owns and controls the land and determines its use? Who ultimately creates the laws?
 - 5 As modern readers, how does the outcome of this story inform our responsibility to care for the land and the vulnerable members of our communities? How does the narrative suggest that fulfilling those responsibilities is a matter of being faithful and obedient to God?
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CLOSING PRAYER

Steadfast God, you hear the voices of those who ask to be seen and treated justly. Give us courage to speak, humility to listen, and wisdom to change what causes harm. Help us care for the gifts you have entrusted to us. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

LESSON FIVE

TAMAR

Genesis 38:6–26



OPENING PRAYER

God of Love, open our hearts and minds as we turn to the tangled story of Tamar. We ask that you meet us in what is uncomfortable and teach us where you are at work. Through the Holy Spirit, give us compassion to hear this passage well. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

Genesis 38:6–26

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway — or scan the code](#)



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

Tamar: Righteousness When the System Fails

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 In previous lessons, we learned that ancient Israel was an agrarian society in which land, and conceiving male offspring to farm and inherit land, was a key to survival. Recall that childless widows were among the most vulnerable members of society. Now, let's revisit the many aspects of this story that, as modern readers, strike us as odd and disturbing but make sense within this context. What are Judah's instructions to Onan, and what motivates that instruction? What motivates Tamar, and what is she fighting for?
- 2 Who are the villains and protagonists in this story? How does the narrator invite the reader to see Tamar's behavior and her trickery? What aspects of the narrative prompt your responses?
- 3 A prominent recurring character in the Old Testament is the courageous underdog who seeks justice by outsmarting or tricking a more powerful foe. (Bonus points if you can think of any other examples!) What narrative clues establish Judah's authority and social power? Why are stories of trickery so resonant across time?
- 4 The narrator indicates that Onan's behavior was so "displeasing in the sight of the Lord" that God "put him to death." Again remembering the context noted in question 1, why was Onan's behavior so displeasing? (See Deuteronomy 25:5–10 for additional context.) What is the narrator telling us about God's care for Tamar? What broader theological points does the story make about God's care for the socially and economically vulnerable, and our duty of care for them as well?
- 5 Remembering that there are no wrong answers, to what extent are you comfortable finding theological meaning in a story that is troublesome to our modern eyes and ears?



CLOSING PRAYER

God of mercy, you are faithful to us when things get messy and complicated. Send us out with courage, knowing that you are at work in all of the unfinished places of our lives. Help us to remain faithful to you and each other. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

LESSON SIX

THE WIDOW OF ZAREPHATH

1 Kings 17:1–16



OPENING PRAYER

God of Provision, you provide for us in our places of scarcity and fear. As we turn to Scripture, help us notice your everlasting faithfulness as you work through unlikely people. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.



READ THE SCRIPTURE

1 Kings 17:1–16

New Revised Standard Version, Updated Edition (NRSVUE)

[Read online at Bible Gateway](#) — or scan the code



WATCH THE 3-MINUTE BIBLE

The Widow of Zarephath

3-Minute Bible video

Video coming soon — it will play in the online flipbook.



DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- 1 The widow doesn't seem to have received any message from God, and yet in verse 9 we are told that God has said, "I have commanded a widow there to feed you." Look back at the similar statement about the ravens in verse 4. What do these two passages suggest about what "command" can mean? How might God be at work through us even when we have not heard God's voice directly?
 - 2 Elijah, one of the most prominent figures in the Old Testament, is called to speak God's word to kings. Yet God chooses a widow, someone with little social power and almost no food, to sustain him. What do you make of God placing Elijah's survival in her hands?
 - 3 God sends Elijah outside Israel to Zarephath, in Sidon, the homeland of the infamous Jezebel and a center of Baal worship. The widow who lives there is a foreigner, yet she demonstrates faith in Israel's God. What might it mean that Elijah experiences God's power and provision through a foreigner? How does the narrator weigh the importance of faith against ethnic or national identity? What lessons might the original Israelite readers have been meant to learn from this passage?
 - 4 In the video we learn that, in the ancient setting of this narrative, extending hospitality was not just an obligation but a source of honor. God could have provided for Elijah by delivering another miracle similar to the one in verse 4. Instead, God instructs Elijah to enter the widow's home, where she becomes his host. How does this address the widow's needs (beyond her need for food)?
 - 5 Have you ever needed to rely on someone more vulnerable, or less powerful, than you for help or hospitality? How can giving or accepting hospitality be an act of grace?
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CLOSING PRAYER

Generous God, you are gracious in providing for us when our jars are empty. You work through our neighbors and strangers alike. Help us to notice your goodness, welcome the stranger, and trust in your provision. In the name of your Son Jesus Christ we pray. Amen.

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

Optional viewing and reading for classes that want to go deeper.



Orphan, Widow, and Stranger

Lesson 1 · Hannah · 3-Minute Bible · optional (coming soon)

Coming soon — plays in the online flipbook.



Mark's Secret Messiah

Lesson 2 · Two Daughters · 3-Minute Bible · optional

[Watch on Vimeo — or scan](#)



The Gospel of Mark

Lesson 2 · Two Daughters · Yale Bible Study · free videos and study guides for groups

[Read online — or scan the code](#)



Orphan, Widow, and Stranger

Lesson 4 · Zelophehad · 3-Minute Bible · optional (coming soon)

Coming soon — plays in the online flipbook.



Rahab Hides the Spies

Lesson 5 · Tamar · Another trickster narrative · Joshua 2 (NRSVUE)

[Read online — or scan the code](#)



Abram and Sarai before Pharaoh

Lesson 5 · Tamar · Another trickster narrative · Genesis 12:10–20 (NRSVUE)

[Read online — or scan the code](#)



Jesus Recalls the Widow of Zarephath

Lesson 6 · The Widow · Luke 4:25–26 · Jesus names her in his Nazareth sermon (NRSVUE)

[Read online — or scan the code](#)





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